

# HOW YOU TEST IN A RETAIL STORE

## 1 Display

If you're out to shop for a tablet in a retail store, finding out the display quality of a tablet is quite easy. The first test you can do is check whether the tablet has an IPS panel or not. IPS displays are currently the best displays around. To do this test, you need to hold the tablet in your hand and without moving your head, turn the tablet and check the display from all possible angles. If you see any colour shift at less than extreme angles, you can be sure that the tablet doesn't have an IPS display.

Since tablet displays are meant to be interactive, you can check how well the touch responsive-



ness is by comparing displays of various tablets in the store. Another point to keep in mind is that protective glass coatings such as Gorilla Glass make the display much more durable. So, try to buy a tablet which has such protective glass coating.

## 2 Build

If you're buying a tablet from the higher end of the market with a metal construction, you'll be okay. However, most tablets available in the market currently don't offer a



metal construction. To gauge the build quality of such devices, you can move your hand over the entire tablet. This will give you an idea how the tablet feels from different angles. Also, you'll know if the manufacturing process has left any rough edges. Touching it is often enough to observe and distinguish between tacky and cheaper plastic and premium plastic used by different tablet makers.

If the tablet has a removable back, ask the store manager for permission to take it off and do an inspection. You can then know if there are high quality or low quality materials used inside the tablet. You'll also know how strong or flimsy the back cover is. Tactility of buttons such as power and volume rocker are also worth checking before making a decision.

## 3 Performance

As we mentioned earlier, if your budget is over, say, ₹10,000, you won't find stutter or lags in a tablet as far as media consumption is concerned. However, this may not always be true, and this can be checked by analysing the device further. In a retail store, you can get a general idea how powerful the SoC is by opening up the camera and shooting a video for more than five minutes. If

you find the tablet heating up, it isn't a good sign. This means that the SoC won't be able to keep up with resource-intensive tasks and resident heating issues will heat up the battery.

You can also ask the retail manager if you can connect the tablet to the internet available in the store to run browser-based benchmarks such as SunSpider. And finally, you can test how the tablet handles apps open in the background by opening as many apps that come preinstalled on the tablet.

## 4 Battery and Camera

While most tablets will offer a larger battery than what your smartphone, you won't be able to test by yourself how many hours the specific tablet will last you by any test



while standing in the store. However, there's a trick by which you can get an rough estimate of how long the battery pack lasts. Since in a retail shop, devices are put up on display, you can easily tap into the battery settings and check how much battery various processes are taking. In latest Android tablets, you'll get a graph as well showing how the battery is being used and by which processes.

Processing power of an SoC is further quantified by the number of cores of a certain microarchitecture it holds. This means a quad-core processor with Cortex-A53 CPUs will offer better performance over an octa-core processor with Cortex-A7 CPUs. However, this is still very complex with the range of custom architectures available from Qualcomm, NVIDIA, Samsung and Apple.

## RAM

The more the RAM, better the multitasking abilities. This law is relevant for almost all computing devices across the board, be it PC's, smartphones or the one we are inter-

ested in currently, tablets. While day to day multi-tasking can be handled easily by 1GB of RAM, a 2GB or more RAM is suggested if you want anything more than that from your tablet. Currently most budget tablets come with atleast 2GB of RAM as standard. You will certainly get more RAM in a few tablets as you go higher up the price ladder. However, unlike smartphone RAM which are now touching 4GB, tablets are currently capped at 3GB.

## Keyboard and I/O

The on-screen keyboard of a tablet would certainly be better for typing than typing on your smartphone, and in some cases

good enough to type for fairly long periods. However, if you really want to get some work done, nothing beats a physical keyboard. All three major operating systems you will find on a tablet offer keyboard support via bluetooth, though it can vary from manufacturer to manufacturer. However, Microsoft Windows powered tablets may have an edge over the other two operating systems here as most tablets running the Windows OS generally bring along a physical keyboard as an optional extra. On the other hand if you are planning to invest in a iOS or Android powered tablet, don't worry, there are numerous third party keyboards available to suit your budget. **4**